certain key sectors like food, water, housing, education, health and employment as focus areas," adds Pankaj Jha, media advisor to the CM.

Areas of Action

At a time when every leader is projected as a brand, the low-profile Vishnu Deo Sai has yet to put down his signature style in the CM's office. It hasn't escaped the Opposition's notice. Chhattisgarh Congress spokesperson Sushil Shukla says, "There is an impression in Chhattisgarh that the government is being run by remote control from Delhi. On tackling Maoism, the CM and his deputy CM have been speaking at variance. This is bound to happen when junior ministers have been appointed."

Currently, first on Vishnu Deo's priority list is the task of making good on the promises in the BJP election manifesto—a bouquet of welfare measures under the sobriquet Modi ki Guarantee. Two of the most prominent are the state government buying 14.5 million tonnes paddy from 2.4 million farmers at Rs 3,100 per quintal, much more than the MSP (minimum support price) of Rs 2,183 and a Ramlalla Darshan scheme, under which the first train with devotees has made a trip to Ayodhya. "All Modi ki Guarantee promises would be fulfilled," says Vishnu Deo.

The BJP accuses the Bhupesh Baghel-led Congress government of not fully implementing various central welfare measures. "Hardly any work was done in the PM Awas Yojana and the piped water supply scheme. The Vishnu Deo government approved housing units for 18 lakh beneficiaries; under the Mahtari Vandan scheme, 70 lakh women have started getting Rs 1,000 a month in their accounts from March 10," adds Jha. However, the Congress disputes the figures. "There is a discrepancy between the number of beneficiaries claimed under Mahtari Vandan and those who are actually getting the money. A similar issues plagues the



"MAOISTS WILL FACE AN IRON HAND"

From his rise through the BJP's ranks and his electoral journey to tribal rights, anti-Maoist strategy and the coming Lok Sabha polls, Chhattisgarh chief minister VISHNU DEO SAI spoke with Rahul Noronha on a range of issues in a candid interview. Excerpts:

Q. Among the new BJP CMs in Madhya Pradesh, Rajasthan and Chhattisgarh, you are the only one who came with years of experience. Why do you think were you chosen?

A. The BJP does not practise vote bank politics. Every worker is capable of holding any responsibility. A simple worker like me became MLA, MP, Union minister...this is possible only in the BJP. In contrast, for the Congress, 10 Janpath is the priority, not the people.

I began public life in the RSS and Vanvasi Kalyan Ashram. But, yes, the journey from panch to sarpanch, MLA, MP and Union minister would be useful in discharging my duties.

Q. Every CM has a vision for the state and formulates policy accordingly. What is Vishnu Deo Sai's vision for Chhattisgarh?

A. PM Modi has stated that there should be a qualitative difference in the lives of the poor, tribals and farmers. These are my guiding principles. On March 10, we have deposited Rs 1,000 each in the accounts of 70 lakh women; on March 12, we have released Rs 13,000 crore as payment of bonus for 24 lakh paddy farmers. The first cabinet meeting announced the funding of houses for 18 lakh people.

Q. You are the first tribal CM of Chhattisgarh. What issues do tribals face in the state?

A. The tribal society preserves forests, mineral resources, culture and national integration, but has largely remained at the fringes of development for a long time. In Chhattisgarh, we are taking steps to promote health, education and livelihood among the tribals.

Q. The Adani group began cutting trees in some of the most pristine forests for a coal mining project. This was opposed by the Congress and tribals.